The Family Tree

By Karen Smith Vastola

INTRODUCTION

ELIZABETH: No one ever seems to pay religion much mind until they absolutely have to. You don't focus on where you're going to spend eternity until you find out just how close that eternity is. You begin to think differently when you realize your day is coming sooner than you had expected. There are so many questions to be answered. What's going to happen to you after you die? What's going to happen to your family after you die? It may be time to re-evaluate this whole "religion" thing, and what better place to start than "The Family Tree" by Karen Smith Vastola.

(Cancer has taught Elizabeth to prepare for the future. Here, she explains why she's become a Methodist.)

ELIZABETH: Do you know I've recently changed religions? I mean, I've become a member of another faith, so to speak. Do you find that interesting? I find it amazing. Or at least, found it amazing. Now, I think nothing of it. As if I were always a Methodist. Born a Methodist. Not the Roman Catholic that I was baptized when I was six weeks old. My mother. God. My mother was horrified. Horrified. When I broke the news, about being a Methodist. Although there's not much to become. You just show up at the church on Sundays, sing some John Wesley hymns, and join your fellow parishioners for coffee and cookies after the service. Anyway, I told my mother on New Year's Eve. It had become a particularly boring moment in the festivities, the family party we have every New Year's. It was about ten-thirty. Everyone was laying allover the chairs and sofas in my sister's living room

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after having eaten and drunk too much. All except me, I hadn't drunk a thing. Methodists don't drink. That seemed to be another good reason to be a Methodist. There must be a lot of alcoholics in the Methodist church. Or recovering alcoholics. I was one. I hadn't had a drink in five years. I quit for health reasons. What a joke. So this was my fifth year of sobriety at the family New Year's party. And you know how those things go. You could always use a good buzz on to get through those things. So I was sitting there thinking about that fact and I tried to think of something I could say to liven things up. You know something I would probably say if I did have a good buzz on. I mean here we are, an hour and a half to ball-drop time. No one's talking. Everyone's just laying there staring at the twentieth century fireplace-the television.

Only during the holidays it's not even television, if there is a child under twenty around or an adult male-it's Nintendo! We're all staring at the James Bond Golden-Eye Game. You know *(Hum theme music.)* daada dadad dada. My nephew has worked his way up from pistol to flame thrower to a.k.70. And I think, why not now? Why not drop the news right now. They can't be really angry with me for turning my back on eighteen years of Catholic education. They'll be grateful to throw some insults my way. They should thank me for relieving the boredom. So I say, nice and loud, to wake up the ones that are sleeping with their eyes open. "You know Janey and I have been going to the Methodist church for the past couple months." "What?" my mother says. That got her. She was just about to nod off into REM

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sleep, but that statement brought her back. "Now, Elizabeth, don't tell me you're going to a Methodist church. Roaring Methodist? And you're bringing your daughter? Now don't tell me you're doing that?" We've been doing it and we both enjoy it. Janey has found a little friend to play with in Sunday school and I like the desserts. "She likes the desserts," my sister screams and almost falls off her chair with laughter. "It worked," I say to myself. Two of them are up and breathing. So I send off another zinger. "I even baked some muffins and poured the coffee myself last Sunday." Well they all carried on for about a half hour with that news. My mother leading the pack with warnings about how once you do a coffee, little by little they'll sucker you into all kinds of activities and before you know it you'll be washing the floors and then sleeping on them because they'll ask you for money and you'll give it all to them and then you'll have no place to live. Like Catholics never ask you for a dime, I could have countered. But I don't say much, just let them rave on. At eleven they run out of juice, but its got their adrenaline flowing again and several of them get up and walk around looking for even more to eat and drink. I'm satisfied with the results. They've been introduced to the topic. Now when my mother calls me on Sunday she won't be shocked to hear I'm at church and that it's not the Catholic one. Let them think what they want; they don't have to know the other reasons I became a Methodist, not yet. Let Janey think she's found a new playmate and not that in some of those Sunday school lessons they'll be some discussions about life and death and the sweet

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hereafter. You know just in case she has to try and understand it and I won't be there to explain. Not that I'm going to die anytime soon. Of course I'm not. The doctors don't think so. It's just that I may die sooner than everyone else I know. Or I may not. Everyone else I know could step off a curb tomorrow and be hit by a truck. That's what the doctors tell me when I want to talk about numbers and probability of cure or re-occurrence. So I'm just warning everyone out there. Don't count on anything. It could happen to all of you tomorrow. Anyway, the church will just be one more thing for Janey that will be there for her if I'm not. And they're all very friendly there and she likes their cookies too. And they'll know her and they would have known me. And that's the other reason I joined the church, because it's small and friendly and they know me. And if the time ever comes. I mean if it comes sooner rather than later, they'll know me and my husband and family won't have to decide whether to slip some old, half-in-the-bag Catholic priest a fifty or a hundred as they try and sum up my life in five simple sentences so that someone I don't even know can stand there in front of a dead person he doesn't even know and repeat the five big occurrences or concerns of my life punctuated by, "God rest her soul," or "She's found her peace now." I really don't want to leave that way. I mean I want some kind of personal association, even if my minister only says, "I liked her cranberry muffins, or sometimes I'd look over at her while she was singing a hymn and I'd see tears in her eyes or she always shook my hand and said good morning and sometimes complimented my

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sermon and she meant it." And he would have known me, when I was alive and not just dead... But that's not something you can easily explain to your family or your mother on New Year's Eve. So let them think I became a Methodist because I like their cookies...1 do like their cookies.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Karen Smith Vastola
Book: The Best Women's Stage Monologues of 1998
ISBN: 1575251841
Publisher: Smith and Kraus
Date (Month/Year): Sept 1999

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